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S

sabbath

The word **Sabbath** means to rest or to stop. The Sabbath is the seventh day of the week for the Israelites, or "Jews." It is a day to rest and worship God. On that day, the Jews often gather together in the synagogue, which is the local Jewish meeting place, to pray and listen to people teach about God. Because festival days were days to rest as well, people often called the festival days "Sabbaths," even if the festival day was not on the seventh day of the week.

The Jews counted days from evening to evening. That means that the Sabbath began on the evening of the sixth day and finished on the evening of the seventh day.

In the time of Moses, God had commanded the Israelites to rest from all their work on each seventh day. God told the people that God had created the world in six days and rested on the seventh day. For that reason, the seventh day was a holy day. The seventh day belonged to God. When people rested each seventh day, people learned that they could trust God for all their needs. People did not need to be working all the time because God was taking care of the people. This day of rest was a beautiful gift of God to the people. The Israelites needed to keep this rest throughout the whole year, even during the busy time of the harvest. When the Israelites kept this day of rest, people from other countries could see that the Israelites were different. It was a sign that the Israelites were God's special people.

It was very important to God that the Israelites did the right things on the Sabbath. If someone did work on the Sabbath, we say that that person did not "keep the Sabbath," or "broke the Sabbath." It was very bad if someone did not keep the Sabbath.

The Sabbath was a day of rest for everyone in a family, even for servants or slaves, and for the animals as well. It was a day of rest for the whole creation that God had made.

God also told the Israelites to allow the land to have a Sabbath rest. For six years, the Israelites could plant their fields, take care of their fruit trees, and harvest their crops. During the next year, the seventh year, the Israelites must not plant, take care of plants, or gather together to harvest crops like the Israelites did during the other six years. Instead, the people were supposed to eat whatever the people could find from whatever was growing on its own. Even without the Israelite people actively planting and harvesting, the plants would still grow things to eat. This helped the Israelites remember that God was the one who really owned the land of Israel and provided food for the Israelites. This rest also helped the land stay healthy, so that the people did not destroy the good soil by farming too much. Every 50 years, the Israelites would have a special rest year, which God called the Year of Jubilee.

By the time of Jesus, the Jewish religious teachers were so careful not to disobey God that they had made many extra rules about the Sabbath day. These rules were very difficult to follow. The religious leaders had forgotten that the day was meant to rest and to honor God. Jesus and the religious leaders had several arguments about the Sabbath. Jesus was often frustrated with the religious leaders because they thought the rules people made were more important than the good law that God had given, and they did not think about what God really wanted.

sabbath

Audio Content
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sacrifice

A **sacrifice** is a gift to God. People often placed the gift on a platform made of earth or large stones, which was called an altar. The purpose for a sacrifice could be that people wanted to thank God for something, worship God, confirm their relationship with God, or ask forgiveness for something they had done wrong. A sacrifice could involve the killing of an animal, which then would be burned on the altar. But the gift could also be food items, oil, or sweet smelling spices.

In the beginning of the Old Testament, there are several stories of people giving sacrifices to God: Cain and Abel, Noah, and Abraham. Later, when God gave the Israelites his law through Moses, God gave the people instructions about how to give him sacrifices. People could not bring their sacrifices to God wherever they wanted: They had to bring their sacrifices to the tabernacle, and later to the temple. The tabernacle was the place where the Israelites worshiped God. It was a tent that the Israelites could carry with them during their travels through the wilderness. Later, when the Israelites had settled in their own country, they replaced the tabernacle with a building, called the temple.

In the tabernacle, and later in the temple, priests were special people whom God appointed to make the

sacrifices on behalf of the people. The priests made sacrifices every day, and there were also special sacrifices for festivals and rituals. People could also bring a sacrifice voluntarily. The sacrifices were very important in the worship of God. Because God is holy, and people are so sinful, people could not just come before God. People needed to be "cleaned" from their sins. Only someone who is purified-made ritually clean-can come before God. The sacrifices helped to make people clean so that they could come before God. However, God also made clear to the people that he did not accept sacrifices if people did not really feel sorry for the bad things that they had done and sincerely wanted to change.

About 40 years after Jesus went back to heaven, the Roman people completely destroyed the temple in Jerusalem. From that time onwards, the Jews could no longer bring sacrifices to God. The New Testament teaches us that Jesus himself was a perfect sacrifice. Jesus died so that God could forgive the people. People do not need to bring sacrifices to God anymore, because Jesus has already made us clean: Jesus has made it possible for us to come before God.

sacrifice

Audio Content
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Sadducee

In the time of Jesus there were 2 important groups of religious teachers in Israel. These were the Pharisees and the **Sadducees**. The Pharisees were very concerned about obeying God's law completely, and they even made up additional laws. They wanted to keep themselves separated from people who did not follow God's law. The Sadducees only followed the written laws in the first five books of the Old Testament. They believed that only the first five books of the Old Testament were important. They did not believe in any life after death, and they did not believe that angels or Satan existed.

Unlike the Pharisees, the Sadducees in Jesus's time cooperated with the Roman government, and therefore they had more political power and influence.

Some of the priests in Jerusalem were members of the Sadducees group. Some members of the Sadducees were also part of the Sanhedrin, the Jewish religious court.

Sadducee

Audio Content
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saint

The word **saints** simply means "holy people." In the Old Testament, holy people, or saints, are people who follow God and his laws-they are God's people, dedicated to him. In the New Testament, all followers of Jesus are holy people, or saints. Holy people dedicate themselves to God and God sets them apart especially to serve and follow him.

saint

Audio Content
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salvation

If you **save** someone, you rescue that person from a difficult or dangerous situation.

Whenever the Israelites were in a desperate situation, for instance when some enemies attacked them, they called out to God to save them. They wanted God to help them and to protect them. If God would not save the people, they would die.

In the New Testament, we learn that all people are in a desperate situation and need God to save them. And God does save us. God saves us because he loves us so much. God saved us by sending his son Jesus into the world. Anybody who trusts in Jesus will be saved. Therefore the Bible says that Jesus is our Savior. We cannot help ourselves. We all need God to save us. Another way to say this is that we all need salvation. God is the only one who can give people salvation. God saves people so that we no longer have to be afraid. We no longer have to be ashamed. We can now have a good relationship with God, and we can trust that even after we die, we will live forever with God.

When you are translating "save" or "salvation," be careful about the following things:

In some languages, you may always have to say what people need saving from. For instance, you may need to say that God saves a person from death, or from punishment. Or you may need to say that a person is asking God to save them from danger, or from dying. You may need to say different things in different passages.

salvation

Audio Content
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Samaria

In the Old Testament, **Samaria** is a city in the north of Israel. In the New Testament, Samaria is the name of a province in Israel. Samaria lay in between the provinces of Judea and Galilee.

In the New Testament, the people who lived in Samaria are called Samaritans. Samaritans were not Jews, but were something like half-Jews. The relationship between Jews and Samaritans was not good. In order to understand this, we have to look at some history.

At some point in the Old Testament, after the reign of king Solomon (the son of king David), the nation of Israel split in two parts. The northern kingdom, which had 10 of the 12 tribes, was called Israel. The southern kingdom, which had the other two tribes, was called Judah.

About 700 years before Jesus' birth, the king of Assyria attacked the northern kingdom and deported the people to other places. This period of time is called the Assyrian exile. It was a common strategy for kings to replace the people in one defeated region with people from another defeated region. That way, it was less likely for local people to become strong again and begin resisting the king. And so, the king of Assyria took many Israelite people away and made them live in other countries. And in their place the king placed people who came from other countries. These people who came from other countries married with the people who were left behind in Israel, and this mixed group of people became the Samaritans.

By the way, we do not hear any more about the Israelite people who were deported to other nations. Their story ended with the Assyrian exile.

However, the southern kingdom of Israel, Judah, lasted a little longer. About 600 years before the birth of Jesus, king Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon attacked and destroyed Judah. The people of Judah are now called Jews, which just means people from Judah. The king of Babylon took many Jews to his own country, just as the king of Assyria had done. But this time, after 70 years, the Jews were allowed to go back to Judah.

So, many Jews went back and settled again in Judah, and rebuilt the cities. When they began to rebuild the temple in Jerusalem, the Samaritans came from the north and wanted to help them. But the Jews did not trust the Samaritans and refused their help. The Samaritans were very offended by this, and they built their own temple instead. About a hundred years before the birth of Jesus, a Jewish ruler destroyed the Samaritan temple. So the Samaritans had some reasons not to like the Jews!

Samaritans considered themselves to be descendants of Jacob, just like the Jews. They believed in God and followed the law of Moses, but they did not accept the other books from the Old Testament. They practiced circumcision, just like the Jews did.

The Jews did not consider the Samaritans as proper Jews. Jews did not interact with Samaritans, and Jews did not even allow a Samaritan to become a Jew by conversion. In fact, Jews hated Samaritans maybe even more than they hated people who were not Jews at all!

In the time of the New Testament, the Roman government ruled over Samaritans as well as Jews. Just like the Jews, the Samaritans were also expecting God to send a Savior. They did not believe that this Savior would be a descendant of the Jewish king David, but they did believe that the coming of this Savior was promised by Moses-just as the Jews believed.

Samaria

Audio Content
mp3 file (2.8 MB)

sanctification

If someone **sanctifies** or consecrates a person they dedicate them or set them apart for God: that person becomes holy. That person is no longer common or ordinary. Someone can also sanctify or consecrate an object. This means that they make the object holy, or something that people can use for God's purposes.

The opposite of sanctifying someone or something is to profane it, or to treat something or someone as common or ordinary instead of as holy.

In the New Testament, people who believe in God through Jesus dedicate themselves to God. They become God's holy people, or people who God sets apart to do God's purposes. These people live godly lives, which means that they are following God in all they do. But people are always growing and learning to live more and more like God wants them to. New Testament authors also call the process of learning to live a godly life sanctification.

sanctification

Audio Content
mp3 file (744 KB)

sanctuary

The word sanctuary means a holy place-a place that is set apart for the worship of God. The word sanctuary is sometimes used as another word to describe the temple of God. It then means especially the central part of the temple. The word temple can be used for the building as well as for the courtyards surrounding it, but the word sanctuary is used only for the building. The word sanctuary can also refer to the tabernacle, the portable tent that the Israelites used as a place of worship before they built the temple.

Because the Holy Spirit lives inside the believers in Jesus, Paul told the believers that their body is also a sanctuary for God. And so even our bodies are meant for worship of God!

sanctuary

Audio Content
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sanhedrin

The **Sanhedrin** is the name for a group of Jewish leaders who are appointed to make decisions on behalf of the people, especially with regards to religion. In the time of the New Testament, Israel was ruled by the Roman people, but the Jews could decide some matters for themselves. These decisions took place in the Sanhedrin. The Sanhedrin listened to court cases and passed judgment based on religious law. When they met for a trial, they usually sat in semi-circles so that they could all see each other. The accused person sat in the middle of the circle.

Another name for Sanhedrin is the **Jewish court**, or the **Jewish Council**.

We do not know very much about the Sanhedrin. It seems that religious leaders like priests, Sadducees, and Pharisees were part of this group. Some wealthy people who were not religious leaders might also have been part of the Sanhedrin. The most important priest, the high priest, was probably the leader of the Sanhedrin.

If you were a member of the Sanhedrin, you were an important person.

The people who made up the Sanhedrin were often against Jesus. They were responsible for handing him over to the Roman government, and for demanding his death. After Jesus's death and resurrection, the Sanhedrin arrested several of Jesus's disciples.

sanhedrin

Audio Content
mp3 file (913 KB)

Satan

The name **Satan** means the adversary, enemy, or accuser. It is the name for the devil, the leader of all evil spirits.

God has created everything that exists, and therefore God also created all the spirits. God created them good, as angels, to do his work. But some angels rebelled against God, and then they became evil spirits. The most powerful of these evil spirits is called the devil, or Satan.

Satan always tries to destroy God's work. Satan tempts people to disobey God. He tries to make people turn away from God by deceiving them. Satan is powerful and dangerous, always looking for ways that he can work against God and against God's people.

Because Satan is still powerful in this time, sometimes the Bible calls him the "ruler of this world." Sometimes Satan is called **Beelzebub**, which means something like "master of the high places." Sometimes he is called the **Deceiver**. Sometimes he is compared to a dragon or a snake.

However, God is much stronger than Satan. When Jesus died and was resurrected, God broke the power of Satan. Even though God is still allowing Satan to use his power for now, when Jesus will come back, Jesus will defeat Satan forever. God will punish Satan and all the evil spirits, and they will never be able to work against God and his people again.

Satan

Audio Content
mp3 file (1.1 MB)

Savior

A **Savior** is someone who rescues people from a difficult or dangerous situation. All people are in a desperate situation and need God to save them. God saved us by sending his son Jesus into the world. Anybody who trusts in Jesus will be saved. Therefore, the Bible says that Jesus is our Savior.

Savior

Audio Content
mp3 file (318 KB)

scribe

Teachers of the law were a group of religious leaders who were experts on the law of God.

The law means the set of instructions that God has given the people of Israel in the first five books of the Old Testament, but teachers of the law also taught all the Scriptures, not only the part of Scriptures that talked about the law. Scriptures refers to the part of the Bible that we now call the Old Testament.

Teachers of the law explained the Scriptures to the people. They did not write down their explanations but told them to their students. Their students memorized their explanations, and taught these explanations to the next generation. People kept adding more and more explanations and discussions about explanations. In the time of the New Testament, these memorized explanations had become very important to the people, maybe even more important than the Scriptures themselves.

In the time of the New Testament, teachers of the law were very important people in the community. People showed them great respect and often called them "Rabbi," a title used for important religious teachers. There were also teachers of the law in the Sanhedrin, the Jewish religious court.

Teachers of the law are sometimes called **scribes**. A scribe means someone who can write. Many people in the times of the Bible were not able to read or write themselves. If people needed to write something, like a letter, they would hire a scribe to write for them. Scribes also copied Scripture so that the text of the Scripture would not get lost. The Scriptures were not written down on paper, the way people do now. Books and paper did not yet exist. Instead, the people wrote Scriptures on long strips of papyrus or parchment. Papyrus is a thin sheet that is made from the fibers of a certain plant, and parchment is made from the skin of an animal. Because those sheets were very long, people rolled them up. The name for such a sheet is a scroll. Scrolls could become damaged quickly, especially those scrolls made of papyrus. Therefore scribes were always busy copying the text from one scroll to a new scroll, so that the text would not get lost.

However, when the Bible talks about teachers of the law, the focus is on their knowledge of the religious law, and not on their writing skills.

When you are translating "teachers of the law," be careful about the following things:

You should not use a phrase that makes your listeners think that these people are teaching the law of a country. Maybe you can use a phrase like "teachers of the religious law," or "experts of the religious law," or "experts of the Scriptures."

scribe

Audio Content
mp3 file (2.1 MB)

scriptures

A **scripture** can mean anything that is written down, but it especially means something that is written down and very important to people. When people in the New Testament talk about the Scripture, or the **Scriptures**, they are talking about the part of the Bible that Christians now call the Old Testament. The Old Testament consisted of what the people sometimes called "the Law and the Prophets" because it was made up of the written laws and instructions that God gave his people through Moses, and the writings of the Jewish prophets. Sometimes this is called the holy Scriptures. The Scriptures are called holy because they tell us about God, who is holy.

Sometimes people talked about something from the Scriptures without saying the word "Scriptures." Everybody knew that if you said "it is written," you meant something that was written in the Scriptures.

The Scriptures were not written down on paper, the way people do now. Books and paper did not yet exist. Instead, the Scriptures were written on long strips of papyrus or parchment. Papyrus is a thin sheet that is made from the fibers of a certain plant, and parchment is made from the skin of an animal. Because those sheets were very long, people rolled them up. The name for such a sheet is a scroll. On both ends of the scroll people attached a narrow wooden handle, like a round stick. When people were reading from a scroll, they would unroll one side of the scroll, and roll up the other end around the stick.

Scrolls could become damaged quickly, especially those made of papyrus. Therefore people who are called scribes were always busy copying the text from one scroll to a new scroll, so that the text would not get lost. Scrolls were expensive. Most people did not own a scroll. Instead, scrolls were kept in the synagogues-the Jewish meeting places. Many Jewish people knew large parts of these scrolls by heart;

sometimes even people who could not read could recite large parts of the scrolls.

Look up “scroll” in the video Bible dictionary.

scriptures

Audio Content
mp3 file (313 KB)

scroll

When people began to write down the stories, family lines, songs, and everything else we hear about in the Bible, books and paper did not yet exist. In those times, people often wrote on scrolls. A **scroll** is a long strip of material on which people would write down stories, laws, histories, family lines, or anything else that people wanted to remember. Usually, people would write on strips of papyrus or parchment. Papyrus is a thin sheet that people made from the fibers of a certain plant. People made parchment from the skin of an animal. Because those sheets were very long, people rolled them up. On both ends of the scroll, people attached a narrow wooden handle, like a round stick. When people were reading from a scroll, they would unroll one side of the scroll and roll up the other end around the stick.

Scrolls were not very strong, and many things could easily damage the scrolls, especially papyrus scrolls. So scribes, people whose job it was to write things, were always busy copying the text from one scroll to a new scroll, so that people would not lose the stories and information on the scrolls.

Scrolls were expensive. Most people did not own a scroll. In the New Testament, people kept religious scrolls in the “synagogues,” which were the Jewish meeting places. Someone would read these scrolls aloud to the community, so everyone could hear what was in the scrolls. Many Jewish people could repeat large parts of these scrolls without reading them. Sometimes, even people who could not read could remember and tell large parts of the scrolls after someone read the words on the scroll aloud.

In 1 and 2 Kings and in 1 and 2 Chronicles, the storytellers often talk about the scrolls that have more information about the history of Israelite kings. Many translations translate the word scroll as “book” in those parts, because many people today do not know what a scroll is.

scroll

Audio Content
mp3 file (1.8 MB)

Sea of Galilee

The **Sea of Galilee** is a sea, or a lake, in the north of Israel. In the New Testament, the part of the country near the Sea of Galilee is called Galilee.

A sea, or a lake, is a place where there is only water. A sea is usually bigger than a lake, but in the Bible the Sea of Galilee is sometimes called a sea, and sometimes called a lake.

The Sea of Galilee was about 20 kilometers long and 10 kilometers wide. If you wanted to walk all around the lake, you would have to walk for one or two days. People often used boats to go from one side of the lake to another side. The middle of the lake was very deep. There were many fish in the lake, and most people who lived in the villages nearby the lake made a living by catching and selling fish. The water in the sea was fresh, which means that it was not salty, unlike the water in many other seas.

Look at a picture of the Sea of Galilee in the video Bible dictionary.

Sea of Galilee

Audio Content
mp3 file (742 KB)

seed

In a plant, a **seed** is the small part of a plant from which a new plant can grow. People can collect the seeds of a plant and put it in the soil to grow more plants.

With humans, the seed of a man is another way to talk about a man’s descendants. When you talk about the seed of a man, you can be talking about one person, or about a group of people who are this person’s descendants.

seed

Audio Content
mp3 file (341 KB)

servant

A **servant** is a person who does work for someone else. Servants may work in the house or in the fields of their master. Servants usually have a low position in the community.

If people do not pay a servant for his work and the servant does not have the freedom to leave his master when he wants, then we call the servant a **slave**. A slave is the property of a master. The master can sell the slave to someone else, just as the master can sell his other property.

Some masters treated slaves cruelly, but other masters were kind and could even treat their slaves as if they were part of the family.

In the Bible, the word for servant and slave is often the same. Sometimes translations use a different word for "servant" to show that this person serves others, but is not a slave.

Because a servant is someone who does work for someone else, storytellers in the Bible sometimes use the word "servant" when they talk about an official or military leader. These officials or military leaders serve their king like a servant serves their master. Though these officials and leaders have a high position in the community, the king has a higher position, just like a master has a higher position in the community than a servant does. Some translators translate these people's roles as "official" or "military leader" instead of servant.

servant

Audio Content
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shekel

The Israelites usually measured the weight of valuable items in units of **shekels**. People used the shekel for different items at different times and places. When a person bought something, people weighed the person's silver in shekels. Israelites also weighed gold, flour, and barley in shekels. The temple weighed offerings based on the sanctuary shekel. And when David was king of Israel, the king determined the shekel's weight. The weight of one shekel was not always exactly the same. But on average, a shekel weighed about 11.4 grams.

Near the time when Nehemiah lived, people began to call some coins "shekels." These coins probably weighed about one shekel. At one time, people from Sidon commonly made a silver shekel with a picture of Sidon's defenses, a ship, and lions on it. People from Tyre commonly made a shekel with a picture of the Phoenician god Baal and Egyptian symbols on it. When Peter took the coin from the fish's mouth, that coin may have been a shekel from Tyre. Shortly after Jesus lived, the Jewish people made shekels with a picture of a special cup and pomegranates on them.

shekel

Audio Content
mp3 file (1021 KB)

shelter

A **shelter** is a temporary construction that people make to live in for a short time. People made the shelters from branches and leaves from a tree.

The Jews celebrated a special festival once a year which they called the "Feast of Shelters," or the "Feast of Tabernacles or tents." During this feast, the Jews made shelters or tents in their gardens or on the roof of their house and lived in these shelters for seven days. This reminded the people that a long time ago, in the time of Moses, God freed their ancestors from Egypt and they had wandered in the wilderness for many years until they settled in the country that God had promised to give them. The shelters, or temporary homes, reminded the Jews that their ancestors had had no permanent place to stay during their years of wandering.

shelter

Audio Content
mp3 file (612 KB)

Sheol

The word hell is a name for a place where wicked people will be punished after they die.

What happens with people after they die? We may find this strange to hear, but the Bible does not very clearly talk about this. Most Christians say that people who believe in Jesus go to heaven, and people who don't believe go to hell. But the people who lived in the times of the Bible did not always have such a clear idea about this yet.

When people in the Old Testament spoke about what happened to people after they die, they said that people went into the "underworld," or "Sheol." They pictured the underworld as a place that is somewhere underneath our own world. Some passages in the Old Testament speak as if all people, good as well as bad, go to the underworld; other passages speak as if the underworld is a place of punishment for bad people only.

In the New Testament, people also speak about the "underworld." Some translations use the Greek word

"Hades" for this. Just as in the time of the Old Testament, the "underworld" sometimes seems to be a neutral place, where all people go after they have died, and sometimes it seems to be a place where wicked people are punished. Sometimes it seems to be a place where all people are waiting until the time that God will judge all people. Sometimes the word "underworld" is just used as another way to speak about death.

Jesus told the people that after death people will either go into the kingdom of God, or they will go into hell. The word hell in the Greek language comes from the name of the place near Jerusalem where at one point in their history the people of Israel had committed a terrible crime. Because of this crime, people avoided this place and began to use it as a place to burn the bodies of dead animals and of people who could not be buried. People always kept a fire burning in this place. Whenever people thought about this place, they felt very bad, and they thought about God punishing people for their terrible crimes. For this reason, people began to use the name of this place as the name for the place where all wicked people will be punished after their death. Jesus makes clear that hell is a terrible place: He uses picture language to describe it as a place with a fire that never goes out, as a place where people will be tortured, or as a place where people will weep and forever regret their choices.

Jesus teaches that hell is also the place where Satan and his demons will be punished.

Sheol

Audio Content
mp3 file (1.9 MB)

shepherd

A **shepherd** is a person who takes care of sheep and goats. Sheep and goats are animals that people keep in order to use their milk, to eat their meat, and to use their hair for making clothes. Sheep are gentle animals. Goats are similar to sheep, but more temperamental, and harder to lead.

A group of sheep or goats is called a flock. A shepherd is responsible for taking his flock to places where they can find the grass or the plants that they need to eat and where they can drink water. A shepherd had to make sure that not any of the sheep or goats got lost. Being a shepherd was hard work, because they sometimes had to walk far with their animals to find enough food and drink for them, and they often had to stay away from home and sleep outside with their animals. A shepherd also had to protect his flock against wild animals. King David, who was the most beloved king of Israel, was a shepherd before he became king.

Because shepherds were so common in Israel, the word shepherd is often used as picture language for a protector or a ruler. God calls himself the Shepherd of Israel. People are called the sheep of God. Jesus calls himself the Good Shepherd, because he gave his life in order that "his sheep"-the people-could be saved from danger.

In the time of the New Testament, some people looked down on shepherds, thinking that they were rough and uneducated people.

shepherd

Audio Content
mp3 file (975 KB)

siege

A **siege** was a way an army could attack a city in battle. Strong cities usually had thick walls and gates to keep attackers out. To begin a siege, an army would first set up tents or temporary structures around the city. This allowed the army to guard the city day and night, so that no one in the city could leave or bring in food, water, or supplies.

The army might also begin to build a tower against one of the walls or pile rocks and dirt to build a ramp to help soldiers get inside to fight. The army might use a battering ram—a heavy log or beam—to hit the wall or city gate over and over again to break it down.

During a siege, the attackers could go and get more food and water. But the people inside the city would eventually run out of these things and become very hungry and ill. So the people would eventually have to come out of the city to fight or surrender, or they would die inside. However, if people had built a strong city and gathered many supplies, it might take an enemy army several years to defeat a city in this way.

siege

Audio Content
mp3 file (686 KB)

sign

A **sign** is something unusual that is happening for a special reason. God can give a sign to tell people that something he tells them is true. For instance, when God promised Noah that he would never again destroy

the earth through water, he placed the rainbow in the sky as a sign. Every time people would see the rainbow, they could remember God's promise.

Sometimes God would give a sign as a warning that something important was going to happen. For instance, God told the priest Eli that both Eli's sons would die on the same day. This would be a sign that everything that God had said that would happen to the Israelites as a punishment for their sins would become true.

Jesus performed many miracles. These miracles were signs that showed the people that Jesus really was sent by God, and that people should listen to what Jesus was saying about God.

Jesus's believers also performed miracles. These were signs that proved that Jesus's believers were speaking the truth about Jesus.

Because a sign is very similar to a miracle, we often hear the phrase in the Bible "signs and miracles" or "signs and wonders."

Signs are helping people to believe, but we have to trust God even when he does not give any sign. If people only trust God when they see signs, they do not really trust God at all. Therefore Jesus refused to perform a sign for people when they asked him to do so.

Even when God does do a sign, only people who are willing to believe him will believe in the sign. Other people will say that the sign is not true or did not come from God.

sign

Audio Content
mp3 file (1.2 MB)

sin

God created the whole world good. God created humankind to be his representatives on earth. God told the humans to take care of the earth. At first, man and woman lived in a good relationship with God, with each other, and with nature. But people began to disobey God. They stopped trusting God, and they wanted to decide for themselves what was good for them. They no longer wanted to accept God's authority over them. This act of rebellion against God is called **sin**. Because of this rebellion, the good relationship that people had with God was broken. Not only that, the good relationship that people had with each other was also broken, and the whole of creation suffered as well.

This rebellion against God comes in many different ways. God has made good laws, and if people follow these laws, then people will be able to live together in peace. But people are constantly breaking God's laws. Any time that a person breaks one of God's laws, they sin.

God hates sin. He grieves when people disobey him, because his rules are for people's good. Therefore, God has to punish people for doing sin. If people persist in doing sin, then the punishment is death.

Jesus teaches us that sin is not only a matter of doing the wrong thing. Thinking wrong things is also sin, even if no one else knows about it. Pride, jealousy, and lust are sin. Looking down on other people is sin. We can do many good things in the eyes of people, but if we are overly proud about what we do, we are still sinning.

The Bible teaches us that Jesus saved his people from their sins. That means that God will not give people the punishment that they deserve. This is because Jesus took the punishment in their place. In the Old Testament, the way for people to ask forgiveness for their sins was by offering God a sacrifice. People had to kill an animal and offer this to God in exchange for their own life. The animal that they offered to God had to be a perfect animal, without any defect. Because of this sacrifice, God forgave them-but only until the next time they sinned. Jesus himself became the perfect sacrifice for all people. Jesus himself had not committed any sin, and so he was like a perfect sacrificial animal. Jesus's sacrifice was so powerful, that because of this God was willing to forgive the sin of all people-not just temporarily, but forever. God will forgive everybody who accepts that Jesus died in their place. These people are now "saved." They do not have to be afraid anymore of punishment. God says that these people now are righteous.

This forgiveness is not cheap! It cost Jesus his life. And so, anyone who accepts Jesus's sacrifice will do his best to stop doing sin, because they are so grateful to Jesus. Paul teaches us that before we were saved, we were slaves of sin. This means we gave in to the pressure and temptation to do sins. But now that God has forgiven us, we are slaves of righteousness-we earnestly want to do the things that please God, instead of doing the things that make him sad.

It is still very difficult-even impossible-for people not to do sins. But God has given his Holy Spirit to help us. The Holy Spirit helps us to see which things are sin, and helps us to resist the temptation to do sin. Without the help of the Holy Spirit, we cannot do this.

When we are saved, we still do sin, but we are no longer sinners. Because now, we repent when we sin. A sinner is someone who continues to do sin, even though he knows it is wrong.

When Jesus lived on earth, the religious leaders were complaining that Jesus ate with sinners. The religious leaders used the word "sinners" to talk about a specific group of people who disobeyed God's laws in a certain way, for instance prostitutes and corrupt tax collectors. The religious leaders, especially the Pharisees, looked down on these people. But many of these so-called sinners who came to listen to Jesus wanted to repent of their sins. Jesus explained to the religious leaders that this was exactly the reason why he had come to earth: to make people repent of their sins. Jesus showed the people that God was happier about sinners who repented, than about people who were so proud that they did not think that they needed to repent.

When you are translating "sin," be careful about the following things:

Some cultures think that some actions are only bad if they are discovered. For instance, they may think that cheating is fine, as long as nobody knows about it-it only becomes a problem when other people find out about it and when it creates embarrassment. The word for sin in the Bible is not like this. Disobeying God is always bad, whether people know about it or not.

Some cultures have a word for sin that means performing a ritual in the wrong way, or doing something that is against tradition, or doing something that goes against your prescribed place in society. This is not what sin is in the Bible. Jesus teaches us that sin has nothing to do with the performing of rituals, but with our thoughts and actions. Even people who perform all cultural rituals and expectations perfectly, are rebelling against God and are sinning.

Some cultures use a word for sin that means "ignorance." This is not what the word sin in the Bible means.

Some cultures have a word for sin that is only used for legal crimes like murder or theft. The word sin in the Bible means much more than only crimes. Even people who never disobey the law of the country, are breaking the law of God and commit sin.

One way to think about how you could translate sin is to do the following activity: In small groups, act out what sin means. Afterwards, decide which of these dramas fit the biblical meaning of sin best. Talk about how the meaning of sin in the Bible is different from what you thought, or from what other people in your community think that sin is.

sin

Audio Content
mp3 file (4.3 MB)

slave

A **servant** is a person who does work for someone else. Servants may work in the house or in the fields of their master. Servants usually have a low position in the community.

If people do not pay a servant for his work and the servant does not have the freedom to leave his master when he wants, then we call the servant a **slave**. A slave is the property of a master. The master can sell the slave to someone else, just as the master can sell his other property.

Some masters treated slaves cruelly, but other masters were kind and could even treat their slaves as if they were part of the family.

In the Bible, the word for servant and slave is often the same. Sometimes translations use a different word for "servant" to show that this person serves others, but is not a slave.

Because a servant is someone who does work for someone else, storytellers in the Bible sometimes use the word "servant" when they talk about an official or military leader. These officials or military leaders serve their king like a servant serves their master. Though these officials and leaders have a high position in the community, the king has a higher position, just like a master has a higher position in the community than a servant does. Some translators translate these people's roles as "official" or "military leader" instead of servant.

slave

Audio Content
mp3 file (861 KB)

sojourner

A person is a **foreigner** or a stranger in a country when they are in a country that is not where that person was born. The original language of the Old Testament has several words for a person who lives in a country as a foreigner. These words relate to the reason the foreigner is in the country. Some foreigners are people who temporarily or permanently live in a country, even though it is not where they were born.

Sometimes these kinds of foreigners move to a new land because there is a war or because there is not enough food in their own land. These people move to the new land, work there, and become part of the community, like a guest who enjoys the hospitality of their hosts. These people may even have some of the same rights as the people who were born in the country. These people often have to follow the same laws, and often the same laws protect them as the laws protect other people in the country. Abraham was this kind of foreigner, or **sojourner**, in Canaan. Later, when Abraham's descendants, the Israelites, made Canaan their own country, God gave the Israelites guidelines about how they should treat foreigners who traveled through their country and who lived there among the Israelites.

Some kinds of foreigners are people who are not from the Israelite people, but they live in the Israelite land and are not really a part of the community like a guest is. Although Yahweh instructed the Israelites not to oppress these foreigners, these foreigners do not enjoy the same rights as the other kinds of foreigners who live in the land. This is often because these foreigners do not worship or honor Yahweh.

Think about the different kinds of foreigners in your country. If you have different words or descriptions for the different kinds of foreigners in your country, be sure to use the correct word for the kind of foreigner you hear about in the Bible passage.

In the New Testament, foreigners often refer to anyone who is not a "Jew," or Israelite. However, God brings these foreigners into his kingdom and family when they accept Jesus. And because those of us who have accepted Jesus are now really a part of God's kingdom, we are foreigners here on earth!

sojourner

Audio Content
mp3 file (1.3 MB)

son

A **son** is the male child of his parents. But people can call someone "son" even if they are not related at all. If you call someone "son," this means you are speaking to that person in a very friendly way. It is usually an older person who calls a younger person "son."

Sometimes people in the Old Testament use the word "sons" to mean someone's descendants, including that person's children, grandchildren, and all future generations from the same family line. If you have a passage where the storyteller uses the word "son" to mean "descendant," you can also refer to the information about the word descendant, and you may use a more general word or phrase that refers to someone's children, grandchildren, and all future generations.

Sometimes storytellers in the Old Testament called the people of Israel the "sons of Israel." The people of Israel are the descendants of Jacob, whom God later called "Israel." In other words, the people of Israel are the sons, or descendants, of Israel.

son

Audio Content
mp3 file (660 KB)

Son of David

Son of David means a descendant of David, even if that descendant is born many generations after David.

David was the most beloved king of the Israelites, and he lived about a thousand years before Jesus was born. God had promised David that always one of his descendants would rule over Israel. But because the Israelites were so disobedient to God, God allowed their enemies to conquer them. The kingdom of Israel stopped existing. But even in this difficult time, God gave the people messages of hope. Through his spokesmen, the prophets, God told the people that a time would come again when a descendant of David would rule over Israel. This king would save the people from their trouble and make everything right again.

And so the Israelites were expecting that one day God would send the people this king and Savior. They called this promised king the Messiah, or the Christ. A Messiah is someone who is appointed for a special task. The Messiah would be a descendant of David. When people in the New Testament call Jesus a "son of David," they mean to say that they believe that Jesus is the special king and Savior that God had promised to send.

Son of David

Audio Content
mp3 file (940 KB)

Son of God

The **Son of God** is a title for Jesus. Jesus is called the son of God because he has a special relationship with God the Father. God and Jesus love each other in the way that a father and a son love each other. Sometimes Jesus is called "the only son of God." This means that the relationship that Jesus has with God is

unique. Nobody else has this same relationship with God as Jesus has.

That Jesus is the son of God means that he himself is also God. Jesus is one person of the Trinity-a word that the church is using to describe that God is one, but at the same time three persons: God the Father, God the Son, and God the Holy Spirit. Jesus has always been the Son of God, even before the beginning of our time, before the creation of the world. When Jesus came to earth, and was born, he also became a human.

When people in the New Testament call Jesus the Son of God, this is sometimes another way of saying that Jesus is the Messiah, the Christ-the promised king and Savior.

When people begin to trust in Jesus, God adopts them as children. Therefore, the Bible sometimes uses the phrase "sons of God" to describe the people who trust and follow Jesus.

Son of God

Audio Content
mp3 file (938 KB)

Son of Man

The **Son of Man** is a title that Jesus gives to himself. Whenever Jesus says something about the "Son of Man," he is saying it about himself. In Hebrew, the language of the Old Testament, this phrase just means "a human being," but Jesus is giving the word a special meaning.

The phrase "Son of Man" occurs in a special way in the Old Testament, in the book of Daniel. Daniel was an Israelite who lived about 600 years before Jesus. At one time he had a vision in which he saw someone who looked like a "Son of Man." In Daniel's vision God gave all authority to this person, and this person became a king, and all the people in the world served him. His kingdom never ended.

When Jesus calls himself the "Son of Man," he is therefore saying to the people: "I am the person from Daniel's vision. I am the king, and God has given me all authority." It is another way of saying that Jesus is the Messiah-the special king and Savior that God has promised to send-but in a less direct way. At the time of Jesus the people did not use the term "Son of Man" as another title for the Messiah. So when Jesus called himself the "Son of Man," the people did not immediately think about the Messiah. However, the people did come to realise that Jesus was claiming to have all authority from God. The people had to figure out slowly what Jesus meant when he called himself the "Son of Man."

The original audience understood that Jesus was talking about himself when he talked about the Son of Man. If your audience will not understand that Jesus was talking about himself, you may need to make that clear. If you would like to make more clear what "Son of Man" means, you can say something like "I who came from God with God's authority."

Or, if you would like to keep the meaning unclear, as it is in the Bible, you may need to make it clear that "Son of Man" is a title. You can say something like "I, the one who is called the 'Son of Man,' or the 'Son of Humanity.'"

Son of Man

Audio Content
mp3 file (1.4 MB)

soul

God created people with a body, and we can touch and see each other's body. But God also created people with thoughts and feelings and desires. We cannot see this part of a person, but we know it is there. This invisible part of a person is in the Bible usually called a **soul**. Even when our body dies, our soul may live on.

Without a soul, a person is not complete. Therefore, the Bible often uses the word soul just as another way of saying "person." For example, in one passage the Bible speaks about "fourteen souls in one family." This simply means fourteen people in a family.

In other places, the word soul refers to the life of a person. Jesus said that he came to give up his soul for the people. This means that he came to give up his life for the people.

The Bible also uses the word "spirit" to refer to the inner, invisible, part of a person. When the Bible uses the word spirit, the focus is on the relationship that a person has with God. When we are praying, our spirit is talking with God. When someone who believes in Jesus dies, their spirit will continue to live with God.

Some people think that the spirit and the soul are the same, and that these two different words are only giving a slightly different emphasis. Other people think that they are different, and that each person has a body, a soul, and a spirit.

When you are translating "soul," be careful about the following things:

Please note that you also need to have a word for "spirit," "heart," and "mind." The words heart, mind, soul, and spirit, all have to do with the inner, invisible part of a person, but each of them has a slightly different use. You may want to listen to the explanations of each of these terms, and then discuss all these four terms together. You can then make a decision about how you are going to translate each of these terms. But remember that in each particular context you have to decide again whether you have chosen the right word. Sometimes one of these words may fit better than another one.

Here is a brief summary of these four different terms:

- **Soul**: the total invisible, inner part of a person. This part of a person may live on even after their body dies.
- Spirit: The spirit is very similar to soul, but with more emphasis on the relationship with God.
- Heart: Heart is picture language for the place where a person's thoughts, feelings, and decisions happen.
- Mind: The mind is very similar to heart, but a bit more emphasis on thoughts, intelligence, and the will, or the desire to do something.

soul

Audio Content
mp3 file (2.1 MB)

span

t308: span

A span is a way to measure how long something is. One span is about as long as the distance between the tip of a man's thumb and the tip of his little finger when the man stretches his fingers as far apart as he can. A span is about 22 centimeters. A span is half the length of a cubit. A span is equal to 3 handbreadths, or 3 widths of a man's hand.

span

Audio Content
mp3 file (323 KB)

spirit

God created people with a body, and we can touch and see each other's body. But God also created people with thoughts and feelings and desires. We cannot see this part of a person, but we know it is there. This invisible part of a person is in the Bible usually called a soul, but sometimes it is called a **spirit**.

When the Bible uses the word spirit, the focus is on the relationship that a person has with God. When we are praying, our spirit is talking with God. When someone who believes in Jesus dies, their spirit will continue to live with God.

Some people think that the spirit and the soul may be the same, and that these two different words are only giving a slightly different emphasis. Other people think that they are different, and that each person has as well a body, a soul, and a spirit.

When you are translating spirit, be careful about the following things:

Please note that you also need to have a word for "soul," "heart," and "mind." The words spirit, soul, heart, and mind all have to do with the inner, invisible part of a person, but each of them has a slightly different use. You may want to listen to the explanations of each of these terms, and then discuss all these four terms together. You can then make a decision about how you are going to translate each of these terms. But remember that in each particular context you have to decide again whether you have chosen the right word. Sometimes one of these words may fit better than another one.

Here is a brief summary of these four different terms:

- Soul: the total invisible, inner part of a person. This part of a person may live on even after their body dies.
- **Spirit**: The spirit is very similar to soul, but with more emphasis on the relationship with God.
- Heart: Heart is picture language for the place where a person's thoughts, feelings, and decisions happen.
- Mind: The mind is very similar to heart, but a bit more emphasis on thoughts, intelligence, and the will, or the desire to do things.

spirit

Audio Content
mp3 file (1.6 MB)

spirit

A "spirit" also refers to any supernatural, non-physical being, such as an angel, Satan, or an evil spirit, which people sometimes call a demon or an unclean spirit. For more information about these different supernatural beings, refer to the Master Glossary entries for angel, Satan, evil spirit, demon, and unclean spirit.

Because God has created everything that exists, God created each of these spirits. God created these spirits good, as angels, to do his work. But some angels

rebelled against God, and these became Satan and evil spirits, which we can also call demons or unclean spirits. These spirits serve Satan and do what Satan tells them to do.

Sometimes biblical authors use the word for spirit, but it is difficult to know whether it refers to a good or evil spirit. For example, in 1 John 4:1–6, John tells his listeners that they should not believe everyone who claims to have God's Spirit, but that they need to listen carefully to the person's message to decide if the spirit they have is from God or not. For more information on God's Spirit, refer to Holy Spirit in the Master Glossary.

spirit

Audio Content
mp3 file (1.0 MB)

statute

A **statute** is a decree or public pronouncement where someone in authority tells the people something that will be important to the people. Usually, the person in authority announces a rule that the people must obey. Often, a statute would be a law or rule about how people should do certain responsibilities in the tabernacle or temple, which were the places of worship. A statute may also refer to a special task someone must do or instructions for how people must live in society.

Sometimes, a statute is a formal announcement about what a person in authority will do. For example, in 1 Chronicles 16:17, the statute is a formal statement that the Creator God, whose name is Yahweh, will do what Yahweh says he will do.

People often use the words "ordinances and statutes" to talk about all of Yahweh's laws. For more information about these words, you can refer to laws and ordinances in the Master Glossary.

statute

Audio Content
mp3 file (695 KB)

steadfast love

Steadfast love is the loyal love of the Creator God, whose name is Yahweh. Yahweh's steadfast love is love that does not change, become less, or end. When Yahweh promises to show steadfast love, Yahweh always keeps that promise. This love is not just a feeling, but an action that Yahweh shows to people. Sometimes translations call this "loving kindness," because Yahweh often shows this love through the way Yahweh kindly helps people. This is the kind of help that a ruler or person in authority gives to someone under their authority. When someone shows this kind of love, this person usually expects the other person to show this love back, because steadfast love happens in a relationship between two people or two groups of people.

Steadfast love can be difficult to describe and to understand. The authors of the Bible can use "steadfast love" to mean three different things.

First, Yahweh's steadfast love can mean Yahweh's ability to save his people from sin and danger. Because Yahweh is loyal and faithful to his people, Yahweh can protect his people from terrible things that can happen to his people.

Second, steadfast love is also a love Yahweh shows to the Israelites, and this love lasts forever. Yahweh made a special promise to his people, the Israelites, to love them forever, and Yahweh keeps his promise. So Yahweh will never stop loving his people! The people have not done anything to earn this love, but Yahweh shows it anyway.

Because Yahweh has this steadfast love for his people, Yahweh requires that people love each other in the same way. Unfortunately, people do not love each other as people should. This makes Yahweh angry, because this steadfast love represents Yahweh himself. But Yahweh's steadfast love can also mean the thing that keeps Yahweh from staying angry! Because Yahweh is a perfect and holy God, sin and bad things in the world make Yahweh angry and sad. But, because Yahweh always loves his people, Yahweh shows his people mercy even when the people make mistakes. This means, Yahweh's steadfast love keeps Yahweh from being angry forever!

Finally, sometimes people in the Bible talk about a person's steadfast love. This person is following Yahweh's example and loving God or other people in a loyal way, without stopping. People often show this love when they keep their promises and act in a kind way, especially toward friends, family, and allies. Someone who loves in this way pleases both people and Yahweh.

steadfast love

Audio Content
mp3 file (1.8 MB)

steward

People in authority choose a responsible person whom they trust to be a **steward**. The steward takes care of the daily routine of a wealthy house or business. A steward may direct and pay the workers, make decisions for the people the steward takes care of, and generally make sure that all goes well. People would respect a good steward.

For example, a wealthy person who had servants would choose a servant whom the wealthy person trusted to be a steward. This servant who became a steward would take care of the entire household. The steward would direct all the other servants, manage the food and supplies for the household, and make sure the wealthy person's family had what the family needed.

In the New Testament, authors would use the word "steward" to refer to people whom God chose to share the good news about Jesus. These authors are showing that God trusts these people with a very important task. These stewards use the gifts God has given them wisely as they direct, guide, and take care of other believers.

steward

Audio Content
mp3 file (688 KB)

strength

Strength refers to someone's ability to do something, or to their physical strength. People sometimes combine the ideas of "heart, soul, mind, and strength" to talk about someone's entire self—their personality, their abilities to do certain things, the decisions they make, and the things that motivate them to do certain things.

strength

Audio Content
mp3 file (234 KB)

stronghold

A **stronghold** is a place where people go to stay safe from enemies. A stronghold is often high up, where an enemy cannot easily attack.

A stronghold can be a natural place in the wilderness, such as a cave or a place in the rocks. These strongholds are often high up, too. In the Bible, David used caves and other natural strongholds in the wilderness to hide from King Saul.

A stronghold can also be a place that people build. For example, a stronghold can be a city or part of a city with a wall to keep enemies out. A stronghold can also be an inner room of a building where people can go for protection if an enemy attacks.

In the original languages of the Bibles, some passages do not clearly show which kind of stronghold they refer to. For example, in some of King David's songs, David said that God is like a stronghold, a safe place of protection. In passages like these, it is best to translate with a general word for a strong, safe place. However, in passages where we know a stronghold is a specific type of physical place, you should use different words in your language to show which type of stronghold it is.

stronghold

Audio Content
mp3 file (749 KB)

synagogue

A **synagogue** is a place where Jewish people are meeting for prayer and for study of the Scriptures, as well as for other types of discussion and teaching.

A synagogue is different from the temple. The temple was the place where people brought sacrifices to God. People did not bring sacrifices in the synagogue. There was only one temple for the Jews, in Jerusalem, but there were many synagogues. We do not hear about synagogues in the Old Testament, but in the time of the New Testament there were many synagogues throughout Israel, as well as in many other countries where Jewish people lived.

The Jews gathered in the synagogues on the Sabbath -the weekly day of rest-and on special feast days. During their gatherings they prayed together, read from the Scriptures, the books of the Bible that we now call the Old Testament, and listened to teaching about the Scriptures.

Each synagogue had a ruler who was responsible for the building and for making sure that everything was done properly. The ruler of the synagogue was in charge of inviting people to come forward to pray, to read from the Scriptures, or to teach.

The Scriptures were written on scrolls-long strips of material made from the fiber of certain plants or from the skin of animals-that were rolled up. These scrolls were kept in boxes inside the synagogue. Scrolls were precious. A special person was in charge of taking out

a scroll from the box and giving it to the person who was going to read.

The synagogue was also used as a school for children, and as a meeting place for people to discuss issues within their community.

When you are translating "synagogue," be careful about the following things:

You should not use the same word as you are using for the temple. You should also not use the same word as you are using for a church building. You could maybe use a phrase like "Jewish meeting house," or "prayer house."

synagogue

Audio Content
mp3 file (1.4 MB)

synagogue ruler

A **synagogue** is a place where Jewish people meet for prayer and for study of the Scriptures, as well as for other types of discussion and teaching. Each synagogue had a **ruler** who was responsible for the building and for making sure that everything was done properly. The ruler of the synagogue was in charge of inviting people to come forward to pray, to read from the Scriptures, or to teach.

synagogue ruler

Audio Content
mp3 file (332 KB)

Syrian Phoenicia

Phoenicia is the name of an area north of Israel. Phoenicia was a narrow strip consisting of five cities on the coast of the Mediterranean Sea.

In the time of the New Testament this area belonged to the country named Syria. For that reason, someone who came from that area could be called a "Syrian Phoenician." Many other people who lived in this area had come from other countries, especially Greece. A lot of people in this area were involved in trade-the buying and selling of goods, especially by means of ships.

Today, this area is part of the country we now know as Lebanon.

Syrian Phoenicia

Audio Content
mp3 file (493 KB)